

The Architecture of Dependence

Preface

Volume I Draft

Preface

This book is not a defence of a school.

It is not a memoir.

It is not a claim of mastery over Dvaita, Advaita, Nyaya, or any other tradition.

It is a philosophical enquiry reconstructed from questions.

The aim is not to persuade.

The aim is to make each question unavoidable before any answer is allowed to stand.

Every explanation, regardless of tradition, is asked the same question:

What explanatory work does this concept actually perform?

Volume I preserves the enquiry as honestly as possible. Traditional claims are presented as current understanding unless they have been verified from primary sources. Where verification is required, the manuscript should say so plainly.

The finished work should read less like an author explaining what happened and more like a mind being forced to become precise.

Some questions remain unanswered.

That is intentional.

An unanswered question honestly preserved is philosophically more valuable than an answer accepted prematurely.

The Architecture of Dependence

Introduction

Volume I Draft

Every philosophical enquiry begins with something that appears obvious.

Happiness.

The Self.

Knowledge.

Suffering.

God.

Liberation.

At first these seem like separate questions.

They are not.

Each depends upon another.

If happiness belongs to the soul,

what is the soul?

If the soul is eternal,

what belongs to it?

If knowledge belongs to the soul,

what is knowledge?

If liberation removes bondage,

what exactly is bondage?

If everything depends upon God,

what belongs independently to the soul?

The enquiry gradually revealed that these were not isolated questions.

They formed a dependency graph.

Following one question carefully always generated the next.

Chapter 1: What Is It That Seeks Happiness?

Volume I Draft

Chapter One

What Is It That Seeks Happiness?

Every enquiry begins somewhere.

Mine did not begin with God.

It did not begin with Vedānta.

It did not begin with trying to prove one philosophy over another.

It began with a much simpler question.

Question

What am I really seeking?

Or am I seeking anything at all?

If happiness is what I seek,

where does it lie?

The question stayed with me.

Almost everything I did seemed to point, in one way or another, towards happiness.

Education.

Career.

Relationships.

Security.

Knowledge.

Even the desire to understand philosophy.

Everything appeared to promise that happiness lay just a little further ahead.

Yet I realised that I had never asked a much simpler question.

If happiness is what I seek,

what exactly is happiness?

Where does it lie?

Does it belong to the world?

Does it belong to the mind?

Does it belong to me?

I did not know.

Another question quietly accompanied it.

Why was I interested in philosophy at all?

I noticed that I was not merely looking for answers.

I was looking for explanations that remained internally consistent.

Whenever one explanation appeared to solve a question while creating another,
the enquiry continued.

It was not enough for an explanation to sound convincing.

I wanted to know whether it continued to remain convincing when questioned again.

Next Question

If happiness belongs to me,

who exactly is this "**me**"?

Before asking where happiness lies,

shouldn't I first understand who is seeking it?

That became the next question.

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Chapter 2: If I Observe It, Can It Be Me?

Volume I Draft

Chapter Two

If I Observe It, Can It Be Me?

The previous chapter ended with a simple question.

If happiness belongs to me,

who exactly is this "**me**"?

The enquiry began with the most immediate possibility.

The body.

Question

If I can observe the body,

am I the body?

The body changes.

Childhood.

Youth.

Adulthood.

Old age.

Health.

Illness.

Everything changes.

Yet throughout these changes,

there remains an undeniable feeling that the one who says "I" continues.

If I can observe these changes,

can I really be identical with the body?

The question did not seem settled.

So the enquiry continued.

Question

If I can observe my thoughts,

am I my thoughts?

Thoughts arise.

Thoughts disappear.

Sometimes they arrive without invitation.

Sometimes they refuse to leave.
Yet I can notice them.
I can examine them.
I can even disagree with them.
If thoughts themselves are observed,
can they be the observer?
The same question appeared again.

Question

If I can observe memories,
emotions,
desires,
and intentions,
can any of them be what I fundamentally am?
One by one,
each appeared to become something that could itself be examined.
The body.
The mind.
Thoughts.
Memory.
Emotion.
None of them appeared to completely answer the question.
Something nevertheless remained.
Not as something I observed,
but as that before which everything else appeared.
The witness.
For a moment,
this seemed satisfying.

Next Question

If everything boils down to the witness,
where does multiplicity come about?

Why do I not experience your thoughts?
Why do you not experience mine?
Why does reality appear genuinely plural?
That became the next question.

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Chapter 3: Why Are There Many Witnesses?

Volume I Draft

Chapter Three

If Everything Boils Down to the Witness, Where Does Multiplicity Come About?

The previous chapter ended with a question that refused to leave.

If I am not the body,
not my thoughts,
not my emotions,
then what remains?

The witness appeared to be the only answer that made sense.

For a while,
that felt satisfying.

Then another question appeared.

Question

If everything boils down to the witness,
where does multiplicity come about?

Where does the world come about?

Where do thoughts come about?

Why do I not experience your thoughts?

Why do you not experience mine?

I did not arrive at these questions by reading philosophy.

I arrived at them simply by looking at the world.

Difference appeared everywhere.

No two people thought exactly alike.

No two experiences were exactly the same.

Even when two people lived through the same event,
they understood it differently.

Difference did not appear accidental.

It appeared fundamental.

The more I thought about it,
the more difficult it became to treat plurality as something that could simply be ignored.

If there is only one witness,

why does reality appear as many?

If there are many,

what explains the many?

The question had quietly changed.

I was no longer asking,

"Who am I?"

I was asking,

"What kind of reality am I living in?"

That question naturally led me towards Vedānta.

Not because I had chosen a school.

Because I wanted to know how each school explained the same problem.

Next Question

If different philosophical traditions all begin with the same world,

why do they explain it so differently?

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Chapter 4: Why Are Souls Different?

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Chapter Four

Why Are Souls Different?

The previous chapter ended with a simple question.

If different philosophical traditions are trying to explain the same world,
why do they arrive at different explanations?

I began reading them,
not to decide which one was true,
but to understand how each approached the problem.

Question

If souls are genuinely different,
what explains that difference?

Were they always different?

Did they become different?

If they became different,
what caused the difference?

If they were always different,
does that itself require an explanation?

As I read further,
one thing immediately stood out.

Advaita began exactly where my enquiry had begun.

The Self.

The witness.

The question,

"Who am I?"

That immediately resonated with me.

Coming from a largely Dvaita background,

I found this interesting.

The first serious philosophical enquiry I encountered began with the same question I had begun asking myself.

For that reason,

Advaita became the first system I explored in depth.

Not because I had accepted it.

Because it was answering the question I happened to be asking.

As the enquiry continued,

another realization slowly appeared.

I was no longer comparing conclusions.

I was comparing explanations.

Some explanations appeared to answer the question directly.

Others appeared to move the question somewhere else.

Others seemed to replace one mystery with another.

I still did not know which philosophy was correct.

That was no longer the question.

The question had become,

"Which explanation continues to remain internally consistent when questioned again?"

That became the method by which every explanation was examined.

Next Question

Advaita appeared to answer the problem of multiplicity through the idea of M■y■.

What exactly does that explain?

Chapter 5: What Does Beginningless Actually Explain?

Volume I Draft

Chapter Five

Does Māyā Actually Explain the World?

The previous chapter ended with a question.

Different philosophical traditions appeared to be trying to explain the same world.

I began with the one that started where my own enquiry had started.

The Self.

The witness.

Question

If everything boils down to the witness,

how does Advaita explain the world?

How does multiplicity come about?

The first idea I repeatedly encountered was Māyā.

At first,

it appeared to answer exactly the question I was asking.

The world is experienced.

Ultimate reality remains non-dual.

For a while,

that appeared satisfying.

Then more questions emerged.

Question

Where does Māyā exist?

If Brahman alone is ultimately real,

can Māyā belong to Brahman?

If it does not,

what is its locus?

As I continued reading,

another expression appeared repeatedly.

Anirvacanāya.

Neither real.

Nor unreal.

Indefinable.

I understood why the expression was being used.

But another question immediately followed.

Question

Does calling something *anirvacanā* explain the difficulty?

Or does it simply describe the point at which explanation stops?

The question was no longer whether the doctrine was elegant.

The question had quietly become something else.

When does an explanation actually explain?

Next Question

If one explanation reaches *anirvacanā*,
what does another philosophical tradition offer instead?

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Chapter 6: What Does Beginninglessness Actually Explain?

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Chapter Six

What Does Beginninglessness Actually Explain?

The previous chapter ended with a question.

If *anirvacanā* marks the point where one explanation stops,
what happens when I ask the same question elsewhere?

I found myself asking the same questions while trying to understand Dvaita.

Question

If souls are eternally different,
what explains that difference?

If they have always been different,
does that itself require an explanation?

One answer that appeared repeatedly was the beginninglessness of karma.

Later I encountered the expression *pravṛtṭih* (during my own enquiry I had initially referred to it as *sampravaha anadi*).

The idea itself was not difficult to understand.

The question that interested me was different.

Question

Does beginninglessness actually explain the difference?

Or does it only explain why there is no first beginning?

If karma is beginningless,
what explanatory work is the word *beginningless* performing?

The more I thought about it,
the more I noticed that the same kind of question was appearing again.

In one place,

I had asked,

"Does anirvacanā explain?"

Now I found myself asking,

"Does beginninglessness explain?"

These were not objections.

They were the same question being asked of two different explanations.

Question

At what point should I say that an explanation has actually explained something, rather than simply giving the difficulty a name?

That question slowly became more important than the individual doctrines themselves.

Next Question

What does it mean for an explanation to be logically satisfying?

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Chapter 7: What Is the Soul Before It Knows, Suffers or Rejoices?

Volume I Draft

Chapter Seven

What Is the Soul Before It Knows?

Until now,
the enquiry had quietly assumed something.
There is a soul.
The soul seeks.
The soul knows.
The soul suffers.
The soul rejoices.
The soul attains liberation.
But another question now appeared.

Question

Before asking what happens to the soul,
shouldn't I first ask,

what the soul itself is?

Every explanation I had encountered seemed to speak about what the soul experiences.
Knowledge.
Happiness.
Suffering.
Liberation.

But none of these answered a simpler question.

Question

If knowledge disappeared,
if happiness disappeared,
if suffering disappeared,
what would remain that could still be called the soul?
At first,
the answer appeared straightforward.
The soul would still remain.
Experiences come and go.

The soul persists.

But that answer immediately created another question.

Question

If every experience can disappear,

what actually belongs to the soul?

What remains even when everything else is removed?

One possibility gradually emerged.

Perhaps happiness does not belong intrinsically.

Perhaps suffering does not belong intrinsically.

Perhaps even knowledge, in its fullest manifestation, does not belong intrinsically.

Then what does?

I found myself reducing the question further.

Not,

"What does the soul experience?"

But,

"What can never be removed from the soul?"

That question became the centre of the enquiry.

Next Question

If I keep removing everything that appears accidental,

what finally belongs to the soul?

Chapter 8: What Belongs to the Soul?

Volume I Draft

Chapter Eight

What Belongs to the Soul?

The previous chapter ended with a simple question.

If everything accidental is removed,
what finally belongs to the soul?

Question

Does happiness belong to the soul?

Or is happiness something the soul experiences?

Happiness appeared to vary.

Sometimes it was present.

Sometimes it was absent.

Something that comes and goes did not immediately appear to belong to the soul's permanent nature.

The same question naturally arose again.

Question

Does suffering belong to the soul?

Or is suffering something the soul experiences?

The pattern seemed similar.

Suffering also appeared to come and go.

If suffering can disappear,
perhaps it too is not intrinsic.

Then another possibility appeared.

Question

Perhaps knowledge belongs intrinsically?

That too seemed difficult.

Knowledge appears capable of increase.

Learning occurs.

Ignorance disappears.

Liberation is often spoken of as fuller knowledge.

If knowledge can become fuller,

does knowledge itself belong to the immutable nature of the soul?

Or does only the capacity remain?

The enquiry continued.

Question

Is experience the only thing that truly belongs to the soul?

Not happiness.

Not suffering.

Not even knowledge in its fullest manifestation.

Perhaps the soul is fundamentally the experiencer.

The one to whom all experiences belong.

For a while,

this appeared elegant.

Then another question emerged almost immediately.

Question

If every soul is fundamentally just an experiencer,

why are souls different?

Have I answered the question?

Or have I simply moved the difficulty somewhere else?

The enquiry had not reached an answer.

It had only reached another boundary.

Next Question

What exactly is meant by **svarūpa**?

When philosophers say something belongs to the intrinsic nature of the soul,

what does that actually mean?

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Chapter 9: What Does Svarupa Actually Mean?

Volume I Draft

Chapter Nine

What Does Svar■pa Actually Mean?

The previous chapter ended with a question.

If happiness,

suffering,

and even knowledge can appear in different degrees,

what actually belongs to the soul?

Every discussion seemed to arrive at the same word.

Svar■pa.

Yet another question immediately followed.

Question

What does *svar■pa* actually mean?

Not as a translation.

As a philosophical idea.

The usual answer was straightforward.

Svar■pa means

the intrinsic nature of a thing.

That which makes it what it is.

That which cannot be removed without the thing ceasing to be itself.

The translation was clear.

The question remained.

Question

How do I know whether something belongs to a thing's *svar■pa*?

A different way of asking the question slowly emerged.

Instead of asking,

"What is svar■pa?"

I began asking,

"What can never be removed?"

If something can disappear,

perhaps it is not intrinsic.

If something can increase,
perhaps only its capacity belongs intrinsically.
The enquiry was no longer looking for definitions.
It was looking for a method.
A way of testing every proposed property.

Question

Can happiness be removed?
Can suffering be removed?
Can knowledge increase?
Can experience disappear?
Each answer seemed to narrow the enquiry a little further.
Not by adding new concepts,
but by removing possibilities.
Yet one difficulty remained.

Question

Suppose experience alone belongs intrinsically.
Why are souls still different?
If every soul possesses the same intrinsic characteristic,
where does individuality come from?
The question had returned.
Difference had not disappeared.
It had merely appeared in another form.

Next Question

Is knowledge the same as experience?
Or are they two different things?

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Chapter 10: Is Knowledge Different from Experience?

Volume I Draft

Chapter Ten

Is Knowledge Different from Experience?

The previous chapter ended with a simple question.

If experience belongs to the soul,

what about knowledge?

Are they the same thing?

Or are they different?

Question

If I experience something,

have I already known it?

Or are experience and knowledge two different things?

At first,

they appeared inseparable.

If I experience pain,

I usually say I know pain.

If I see colour,

I usually say I know colour.

Yet the more I thought about it,

the less obvious the identity appeared.

Question

Knowing arithmetic is not the same as experiencing arithmetic.

Remembering a childhood event is not the same as reliving it.

Does that mean knowledge and experience are related,

but not identical?

Another question naturally followed.

Question

Can there be experience without knowledge?

Or does every experience already involve knowledge?

And if knowledge itself can increase,

does knowledge really belong to the immutable nature of the soul?

Or does only the capacity for knowing belong intrinsically?

The same pattern seemed to appear once again.

Knowledge.

Happiness.

Suffering.

Each seemed to possess

something intrinsic

and

something manifest.

The pattern itself interested me.

Not because it answered the question,

but because it appeared repeatedly.

I resisted treating every case as identical.

Yet I could not ignore the resemblance.

Question

If knowledge,

happiness,

and suffering all seem to possess this same structure,

am I beginning to discover something more general?

Or am I simply forcing different ideas into the same pattern?

The enquiry did not yet answer that question.

It merely recognised it.

Next Question

Does happiness require knowledge?

Or can happiness exist independently of knowledge?

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Chapter 11: Is Suffering a Reality or Merely the Absence of Happiness?

Volume I Draft

Chapter Eleven

Is Suffering a Reality or Merely the Absence of Happiness?

The previous chapter ended with a question.

If experience and knowledge are not identical,

what exactly is the soul experiencing?

One possibility immediately demanded attention.

Suffering.

Question

When I say,

"I am suffering,"

what exactly is happening?

Has the soul changed?

Or has the soul merely experienced something?

At first,

both possibilities seemed difficult.

If suffering changes the soul,

then the soul no longer appears immutable.

If suffering never affects the soul,

why does suffering appear so undeniably real?

Neither answer completely satisfied me.

Question

Where does suffering exist?

Does it belong to the body?

The mind?

The soul?

Or does it belong somewhere else altogether?

Each possibility appeared to answer one question while creating another.

If suffering belongs only to the body,

how do I explain mental anguish?

If it belongs only to the mind,

who experiences the mind?
If it belongs to the soul,
has the soul acquired a new property?
The question refused to settle.

Question

Is suffering merely the absence of happiness?
Or is suffering itself something positive?
Ordinary experience did not immediately support the first answer.
Pain did not merely feel like
"less happiness."
It appeared as something present.
Something experienced.
That made the question much more difficult.

Next Question

If suffering appears positive,
does that mean it possesses its own reality?
Or can something be positively experienced without becoming part of the soul?

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Chapter 12: Is Darkness Merely the Absence of Light?

Volume I Draft

Chapter Twelve

Is Darkness Merely the Absence of Light?

The previous chapter ended with another question.

Can something be positively experienced
without becoming part of the soul?

While thinking about suffering,

I found myself returning to a familiar analogy.

Question

Is darkness merely the absence of light?

If so,

is suffering merely the absence of happiness?

The analogy appeared attractive.

Darkness is often described

not as a thing,

but as the absence of light.

Perhaps suffering should be understood in the same way.

Yet another question immediately appeared.

Question

When I touch fire,

do I merely experience

"less comfort"?

Or do I experience something genuinely positive called pain?

Ordinary experience seemed to resist treating pain as a simple absence.

Pain announces itself.

It has a character of its own.

Yet another distinction now became necessary.

Question

Can something be positively experienced

without existing as an independent reality?

Experience alone did not appear sufficient to settle the question.

Something may be immediately experienced,

yet that alone does not tell me what kind of reality it possesses.

The enquiry therefore remained open.

Question

Suppose a liberated soul once experienced suffering in saṃsāra.

Has the soul experienced something contrary to its own eternal nature?

Or has it merely stood in relation to something contrary to itself?

The difference appeared subtle.

It also appeared important.

I noticed that the question was changing once again.

The enquiry no longer concerned only suffering.

It was beginning to ask a more general question.

What exactly is an experience?

Next Question

If happiness and suffering are both experiences,

where does happiness actually exist?

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Chapter 13: Where Does Happiness Actually Exist?

Volume I Draft

Chapter Thirteen

Where Does Happiness Actually Exist?

The previous chapter ended with a question.

If happiness and suffering are both experiences,
where does happiness actually exist?

Question

If happiness belongs to the object,
why do different people experience the same object differently?

One person delights in music.

Another finds it distracting.

One seeks wealth.

Another willingly gives it away.

One longs for solitude.

Another fears it.

The object remains the same.

The experience changes.

The object alone did not appear sufficient to explain happiness.

Question

Does happiness belong to the mind?

The mind certainly participates.

Yet the mind itself is restless.

What satisfied me yesterday
may leave me indifferent tomorrow.

If happiness belongs entirely to the mind,
why does the mind never stop searching?

Perhaps the mind experiences happiness.

Perhaps it does not produce it.

The question remained open.

Question

Does happiness belong to the soul?

If happiness belongs intrinsically to the soul,
another difficulty immediately appears.

Why do I not experience it all the time?

Can something intrinsic disappear?

If it cannot,
what exactly is absent?

If it can,
was it truly intrinsic?

The enquiry once again returned to the distinction between
what belongs to a thing
and

what merely becomes manifest.

The answer was not yet clear.

The question remained.

Next Question

Can something exist,
yet remain unexperienced?

If so,
what does it mean for something to exist but not be manifest?

Chapter 14: If Only God Is Independent, What Does Independence Mean?

Volume I Draft

Chapter Fourteen

If Only God Is Independent, What Does Independence Mean?

The previous chapter ended with another question.

If happiness,

knowledge,

and even liberation appear to depend upon something beyond the soul,

what actually belongs independently to the soul?

That question slowly led me to another.

Question

If everything depends upon something else,

must there eventually be something that depends upon nothing?

If every explanation depends upon another explanation,

the chain appears endless.

Reason itself seems to ask for something that does not borrow its existence from anything else.

One response I encountered, particularly in Dvaita, described this distinction very clearly.

God alone is **Svatantra**.

Absolutely independent.

Everything else is **Asvatantra**.

Dependent.

Not partially.

Completely.

I was less interested in the terminology than in the structure of the idea.

The distinction itself appeared powerful.

Question

Can there be two completely independent realities?

Suppose there were.

Would each remain completely independent of the other?

If they possess no relation,

how could they explain the same reality?

If they possess a relation,

does that relation itself introduce dependence?

The question appeared to point toward a single independent reality.

Question

If the soul is eternally dependent,

what changes in liberation?

Liberation removes ignorance.

Liberation removes suffering.

But does liberation remove dependence?

The answer I encountered was no.

Dependence does not disappear.

Rather,

dependence becomes perfect.

At first,

that sounded surprising.

Ordinarily,

dependence is associated with weakness.

Yet here,

dependence itself appeared to become fulfilment.

That was a very different way of thinking about freedom.

Question

If happiness depends upon God,

if knowledge depends upon God,

if liberation depends upon God,

what finally belongs to the soul itself?

That question stayed with me.

Next Question

If God alone is truly independent,

what does it mean to say that God is infinite?

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Chapter 15: Can an Infinite Being Completely Know an Infinite Nature?

Volume I Draft

Chapter Fifteen

Can an Infinite Being Completely Know an Infinite Nature?

The previous chapter ended with another question.

If God alone is completely independent,
what does it mean for such a being to be infinite?
As I thought about infinity,
one question kept returning.

Question

If God's qualities are infinite,
and God knows all His qualities,
doesn't that itself place a boundary around infinity?
At first,
the question appeared contradictory.
To know something completely often seems to imply that it has been fully grasped.
And if something has been fully grasped,
has it not become finite?
Yet I found this difficult to apply to God.
Perhaps the limitation lies,
not in infinity,
but in the kind of knower I was imagining.
Human knowledge is finite.
Divine knowledge need not be.
The question nevertheless remained.

Question

When we say,
"God infinitely knows Himself,"
are we describing a completed state,
or an eternal act?
The distinction appeared important.
If God's nature is infinite,

perhaps His self-knowledge is not something that reaches a final point.

Perhaps it is eternally complete,

without ever becoming exhausted.

I did not yet know whether that resolved the difficulty.

The question remained open.

Question

Can mathematics help me think about infinity?

Modern mathematics speaks about different kinds of infinity.

That did not prove anything about God.

Nor did I expect it to.

But it reminded me that infinity often behaves very differently from ordinary intuition.

At the very least,

it cautioned me against assuming that divine infinity must resemble finite experience simply extended without limit.

The analogy ended there.

It clarified a possibility.

It did not establish a doctrine.

Next Question

If God knows every choice I will ever make,

am I genuinely free?

Chapter 16: If God Already Knows Every Choice, Am I Truly Free?

Volume I Draft

Chapter Sixteen

If God Already Knows Every Choice, Am I Truly Free?

The previous chapter ended with a question.

If God perfectly knows Himself,
what does it mean for God to know everything else?
One question immediately followed.

Question

If God already knows every choice I will ever make,
am I genuinely free?

At first,
the difficulty appeared obvious.
If every future choice is already known,
doesn't that make the future fixed?

And if the future is fixed,
where is freedom?

One response distinguished
knowledge
from
causation.

Knowing an event does not necessarily cause the event.

That seemed reasonable.

Yet another question immediately appeared.

Question

The problem isn't simply that God knows.

The problem is that God knows **before** I choose.

Doesn't that make all the difference?

The more I thought about it,
the more another possibility emerged.

Perhaps the word **before**
already assumes that God exists within time.

If God is not another being moving through moments as I do,
perhaps "before" and "after" cannot be applied in the same way.

That did not answer the question.

It only made me realise that I might be asking a question about time,
while believing I was asking a question about freedom.

Question

If God stands outside time,
what does "the future" even mean from God's perspective?

At this point,

I realised I did not yet understand time well enough to answer the original question.

Rather than forcing an answer,

I left the question open.

Next Question

If God possesses the power to liberate,
why are all souls not liberated?

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Chapter 17: If God Can Grant Liberation, Why Not Liberate Every Soul?

Volume I Draft

Chapter Seventeen

If God Can Grant Liberation, Why Not Liberate Every Soul?

The previous chapter left another question unresolved.

If God possesses complete knowledge,
complete power,
and perfect compassion,
why does suffering continue?

The question gradually became more specific.

Question

If every soul seeks happiness,
why doesn't God simply grant liberation to every soul?

One response I encountered distinguished

God's compassion

from

the intrinsic nature of souls.

According to the Dvaita tradition,

souls are not merely different because of their experiences.

They differ intrinsically.

This eventually led me to the doctrine of

mukti-yogyatva

and the threefold classification of souls.

I was less interested in the terminology
than in the question it was trying to answer.

Question

If every soul seeks happiness,
isn't liberation what every soul ultimately wants?

The response surprised me.

Perhaps not every soul seeks the same happiness.

Perhaps what appears as fulfilment to one soul
does not appear as fulfilment to another.

If that is true,
then the question is no longer simply about liberation.
It becomes a question about desire itself.

Question

If a soul rejects God,
is it rejecting happiness?
Or is it experiencing something else as happiness?
This seemed to move the discussion to a deeper level.
Perhaps the disagreement was not about knowledge.
Perhaps it was about the very nature of what different souls seek.
I found the question difficult,
not because I had rejected the answer,
but because I wanted to understand exactly what it meant.

Question

If different souls ultimately seek different ends,
does justice require that every soul receive the same destiny?
Or does justice consist in every soul reaching the end consistent with its own intrinsic nature?
The question remained open.
It also became one of the deepest questions in the enquiry.

Next Question

If souls differ intrinsically,
what exactly is the nature of that intrinsic difference?

Chapter 18: How Does Beginningless Karma Become My Karma?

Volume I Draft

Chapter Eighteen

How Does Beginningless Karma Become *My* Karma?

The previous chapter ended with a question about the intrinsic nature of souls.

As I tried to understand the Dvaita explanation, another question gradually became unavoidable.

Question

If karma is beginningless,

how does it become **my** karma?

The soul and karma appear to be distinct.

One is the experiencer.

The other determines the experiences that unfold.

That immediately led me to another question.

Question

If the soul and karma are different entities,

how did the relation between them arise?

Several possibilities appeared.

If God established the relation,

then the relation itself appears to have a beginning.

If the relation has a beginning,

in what sense is karma beginningless?

Another possibility seemed to be that no one established the relation.

But that immediately raised another question.

Question

If nobody established the relation,

how does the relation exist at all?

Perhaps the relation itself is beginningless.

That appeared to answer one difficulty.

Yet another immediately appeared.

Question

If the relation itself is beginningless,

have I explained the relation?

Or have I merely said that it has always existed?

The question did not arise because I doubted the tradition.

It arose because I wanted to understand exactly what the explanation was claiming.

The enquiry had slowly shifted.

I was no longer asking,

"What is karma?"

I was asking,

"What explanatory work is the idea of beginninglessness actually doing?"

Next Question

Is this fundamentally different from saying something is *anirvacan*■*ya*?

The Architecture of Dependence

Chapter 19: Does Beginninglessness Actually Explain?

Volume I Draft

Chapter Nineteen

Does Beginninglessness Actually Explain?

The previous chapter ended with another question.

If the relation between soul and karma is beginningless,
what exactly has been explained?

Question

What does *pravṛtṭihānādi* actually explain?

During my own enquiry, I first referred to this idea as *sampravaha anadi*. Later, I realised that the traditional terminology required verification. What interested me, however, was never the terminology itself.

It was the explanatory role of the idea.

Question

Does beginninglessness explain why souls differ?

Or does it only explain why there is no first beginning?

The more I thought about it,
the more another comparison appeared.

Earlier,

I had encountered the word

anirvacanāya.

Now,

I was encountering

pravṛtṭihānādi.

The traditions were different.

The terminology was different.

Yet I found myself asking a similar question of both.

Question

How is this different from *anirvacanāya*?

Have I reached two different traditions,
each arriving at a point where explanation no longer proceeds?

Or are they doing fundamentally different philosophical work?

I resisted assuming they were the same.

They belong to different metaphysical systems.
Yet the comparison itself appeared unavoidable.
The enquiry therefore became more careful.
I was no longer comparing doctrines.
I was comparing the logical role each doctrine played.

Question

When should I say,
"I now understand the explanation,"
rather than,
"I have learned a new word"?
That question remained unanswered.
It also became one of the most important questions in the entire enquiry.

Next Question

While thinking about beginninglessness,
why did modern physics suddenly come to mind?

The Architecture of Dependence

Chapter 20: Why Did Physics Enter This Enquiry?

Volume I Draft

Chapter Twenty

Why Did Physics Enter This Enquiry?

The previous chapter ended unexpectedly.

I had been thinking about karma.

Instead,

I found myself thinking about physics.

Question

Why did modern physics suddenly enter a philosophical enquiry?

It was not because I thought physics proved Vedānta.

Nor because Vedānta anticipated modern physics.

The comparison arose for a different reason.

Both enquiries seemed to distinguish between

what exists,

and

what becomes manifest.

That immediately caught my attention.

Question

Modern physics speaks about fields.

Electromagnetic fields.

Photon fields.

Quantum fields.

These are not ordinarily seen directly.

Their effects are.

Could this help me think about karma?

Not as physical energy,

but as a similar explanatory structure?

Another question naturally followed.

Question

Physics also speaks about potential.

Energy may exist before it becomes observable.

Matter itself may be understood through transformations such as $E = mc^2$.

Could beginningless karma be understood in a structurally similar way?

Not because karma is energy.

Not because physics explains metaphysics.

But because both appear to distinguish between

potential

and

manifestation.

The comparison immediately encountered its own limits.

Fields are measurable.

Karma is not.

Physics investigates physical causation.

Karma concerns moral causation.

The analogy therefore could not be extended indefinitely.

Yet it continued to illuminate one question.

Question

Could beginningless karma be understood as a kind of metaphysical potential,

which later becomes manifest through experience?

Or am I forcing a physical model onto a metaphysical idea?

Another thought quietly appeared.

Perhaps I had been comparing the wrong things all along.

Question

Am I comparing substances?

Or am I comparing explanatory structures?

The distinction appeared decisive.

The enquiry was never trying to prove Vedānta through science.

It was asking whether two very different disciplines sometimes solve similar logical problems using similar patterns of explanation.

The answer remained open.

The comparison itself had already become worthwhile.

Next Question

Can analogies ever explain?

Or do they merely help us think more clearly about questions that remain unresolved?

The Architecture of Dependence

Chapter 21: Can Svabhava Explain Difference?

Volume I Draft

Chapter Twenty-One

Can Svabhava Explain Difference?

The previous chapter ended with another question.

Perhaps I had been comparing explanatory structures rather than substances.

That thought refused to leave.

It gradually led me to another question.

Question

Modern physics speaks about different fields.

Each field manifests differently.

An electron field never manifests as a photon.

A photon field never manifests as an electron.

The possibilities themselves appear constrained by the nature of the field.

Could something structurally similar help me think about **svabhava**?

Not because the two are the same.

But because both appear to ask whether intrinsic nature constrains manifestation.

Question

If souls possess different **svabhavas**,

could those intrinsic natures naturally determine the range of karmic manifestations?

If so,

perhaps karma is not merely imposed upon a soul.

Perhaps karma unfolds consistently with that soul's own intrinsic nature.

The question remained open.

Question

If the bodies we receive in **samsara** arise according to karma,

and karma itself is beginningless,

does that mean every embodied soul exists in a mixed condition?

If so,

what exactly is mixed?

The body?

The mind?

The karma?

Or the soul itself?

Question

Suppose a soul is intrinsically *sattvika*.

Can a mixed stream of karma ever produce actions contrary to that soul's intrinsic nature?

Or will even mixed karma always unfold consistently with its *svabhava*?

If that is true,

then perhaps **karma and *svabhava* are never in conflict.**

Perhaps karma is one way in which *svabhava* becomes manifest.

The enquiry stopped there.

Not because the question had been answered,

but because another question immediately appeared.

Question

Does *svabhava* determine karma?

Or does karma shape *svabhava*?

Or are both beginningless,

making the very idea of "which came first?" the wrong question?

Another possibility occurred to me.

Suppose every embodied soul enters the same world.

The same material nature.

The same opportunities.

The same field of action.

Why then do souls respond so differently?

Perhaps *samsara* is not primarily revealing the world.

Perhaps it is revealing the soul.

If that is true,

then embodiment does not create intrinsic difference.

It manifests it.

Question

If that is true,

what exactly is the role of God?

Is God assigning karma?

Is God assigning bodies?

Or is God providing the field within which each soul's beginningless nature and beginningless karma unfold according to perfect justice?

The enquiry had arrived at a place I had not anticipated.

The question was no longer only about karma.

Nor only about **svabhāva**.

It had quietly become a question about justice itself.

Next Question

If God is perfectly just,

why must a soul ever experience anything that appears contrary to its own intrinsic nature?

The Architecture of Dependence

Chapter 22: Does Samsara Reveal the Soul or Change It?

Volume I Draft

Chapter Twenty-Two

Does Saṃsāra Reveal the Soul or Change It?

The previous chapter ended with a question.

If souls possess different *svabhāvas*,

what exactly is the purpose of saṃsāra?

Question

Does saṃsāra change the soul?

Or does it merely reveal what the soul already is?

Both possibilities appeared significant.

If saṃsāra changes the intrinsic nature of the soul,

then *svabhāva* itself no longer appears intrinsic.

But if saṃsāra never changes the soul,

another question immediately appears.

Question

Then why does saṃsāra exist at all?

Perhaps saṃsāra is not primarily a place of transformation.

Perhaps it is a place of manifestation.

A soul acts.

Experiences.

Chooses.

Responds.

Yet through those actions,

something deeper gradually becomes visible.

Not to God.

But to the soul itself.

Question

If embodiment merely manifests what already exists,

does suffering transform the soul?

Or does suffering reveal the soul?

That distinction appeared important.

One suggests change.

The other suggests disclosure.

The enquiry remained open.

Question

If liberation is attained,

has the soul become something new?

Or has its intrinsic nature simply become fully manifest?

The question had quietly returned to the same place.

Manifestation.

The idea appeared once again.

Not through physics.

Not through karma.

But through liberation itself.

Next Question

If God is perfectly just,

why should any soul ever experience what appears contrary to its own intrinsic nature?

The Architecture of Dependence

Chapter 23: If God Is Neutral, Why Must Souls Suffer?

Volume I Draft

Chapter Twenty-Three

If God Is Neutral, Why Must Souls Suffer?

The previous chapter left another question unresolved.

If saṃsāra reveals rather than changes the soul,
why must suffering exist at all?

Question

If God is perfectly just,
why should a soul ever experience suffering that appears contrary to its own intrinsic nature?

This question did not arise from doubt about God's justice.

It arose from trying to understand it.

If a soul is intrinsically inclined toward God,
why should it undergo experiences that appear opposed to that inclination?

If suffering teaches,
what is it teaching?

If suffering purifies,
what is being purified?

If suffering merely manifests karma,
why is manifestation itself necessary?

Question

Does suffering reveal the soul?

Or is it intended to change the soul?

The distinction appeared to matter.

If suffering changes the soul,
then saṃsāra becomes a process of transformation.

If suffering reveals the soul,
then saṃsāra becomes a process of disclosure.

The two possibilities lead to very different understandings of justice.

Question

Could a perfectly just God permit suffering,

not to change what a soul is,
but to allow what it already is to become manifest?
I did not yet know.
The question remained open.

Question

If God is neutral,
what exactly does neutrality mean?
Does neutrality mean treating every soul identically?
Or does it mean responding perfectly to the intrinsic nature of each soul?
The enquiry had reached another boundary.
Justice itself now required explanation.

Next Question

If every soul receives the same opportunity,
must every soul reach the same destination?

The Architecture of Dependence

Chapter 24: Does Equal Opportunity Require Equal Destiny?

Volume I Draft

Chapter Twenty-Four

Does Every Soul Ultimately Seek Happiness?

The previous chapter ended with a question.

If different souls possess different intrinsic natures,
do they ultimately seek the same end?

The question immediately returned me to where the enquiry had begun.

Question

Does every soul ultimately seek happiness?

At the beginning of this enquiry,
the answer appeared obvious.

Everything I observed seemed directed toward happiness.

Knowledge.

Wealth.

Power.

Relationships.

Even suffering was often endured for the sake of some greater happiness.

The assumption appeared universal.

Yet another question slowly emerged.

Question

Suppose a soul delights in causing suffering.

Is it still seeking happiness?

Or is it seeking something fundamentally different?

The question became even more difficult when I considered the Dvaita understanding of **tamo-yogya** souls.

If a soul ultimately moves toward darkness,
does it nevertheless believe it is moving toward happiness?

Or does the very meaning of happiness differ according to the intrinsic nature of the soul?

If the latter is true,
then perhaps my first question had been incomplete.

Perhaps every soul seeks what appears fulfilling according to its own **svabhāva**.

Whether that fulfilment is objectively the highest good remained another question.

Question

If happiness itself manifests differently according to **svabhāva**,

does every soul truly seek the same end?

Or do different souls seek fundamentally different fulfilments?

The enquiry had quietly returned to its beginning.

Not to repeat the first question.

To understand it more deeply.

Perhaps the question was never simply,

"Does every soul seek happiness?"

Perhaps it was,

"What does happiness mean for different souls?"

Another analogy occurred to me.

A grain of rice reaches us covered by its husk.

The husk and the grain appear together.

So naturally together,

that separating them requires effort.

Yet no one mistakes the husk for the grain.

Question

Could beginningless karma relate to the soul in a similar way?

Not because karma is the soul.

Nor because the soul is karma.

But because the two appear together from the very beginning of our enquiry into **saṃsāra**.

The analogy did not explain beginninglessness.

It merely helped me think about the relation.

Could there ever have been a grain without its husk?

Perhaps.

But that is no longer the grain we ordinarily encounter.

Likewise,

could there ever be a soul encountered in **saṃsāra** without beginningless karma?

The question remained open.

Question

If karma has always accompanied the embodied soul,
does that mean karma belongs to the soul?
Or has beginninglessness simply made the relation inseparable without making it intrinsic?
The enquiry had returned to the same boundary once again.
Beginninglessness.
Relation.
Intrinsic nature.
Manifestation.
None of these questions stood alone any longer.
Each seemed to depend upon the others.

Next Question

If different svabhāvas always manifest different karmic streams,
are svabhāva and karma two different realities?
Or are they inseparable aspects of the same beginningless order?

The Architecture of Dependence

Invitation to the Conversation

Volume I Draft

Part XI: Conversation With Tradition

Volume I remains the enquiry.

This part opens the door to Volume II.

The purpose is not to decorate the manuscript with famous names.

The purpose is to ask one question.

> **Who, in the history of philosophy, asked the closest version of this exact question?**

The questions choose the participants.

Not the traditions.

Not the reputations.

Not the conclusions.

Only the question.

Possible participants include:

? Madhva

? Jayatirtha

? Vyasatirtha

? Vijayeendra

? Raghavendra

? ■a■kara

? Madhus■dana Sarasvat■

? R■m■nuja

? Aristotle

? Plato

? Bertrand Russell

? Georg Cantor

? Saul Kripke

This list is intentionally incomplete.

No thinker enters the conversation unless the question genuinely requires them.

Symposium Method

Every conversation follows the same structure.

1. The Enquirer

The original question is reproduced exactly as it arose during the enquiry.

Only grammar may be corrected.

The philosophical content is never rewritten.

2. Current Understanding

What has the enquiry understood so far?

What assumptions are already being made?

3. The Tradition

How does the philosopher or tradition answer this question?

Primary sources take precedence whenever possible.

4. Comparative Philosophy

Do other traditions recognise the same difficulty?

Are they answering the same question?

Or a different one?

5. Notebook

What questions remain?

What new questions arise?

These become the starting point of the next enquiry.

Example

Can an Eternal Soul Experience Something Contrary to Its Nature?

Question

If the soul's essential nature never changes,

how can it genuinely experience suffering?

Traditional Dvaita Response

To be verified from primary sources.

Question for Advaita

Does the empirical–ultimate distinction resolve this difficulty,

or does it relocate it?

Comparative Philosophy

The distinction between essential and accidental properties may become relevant.

Would Aristotle,
or later analytic philosophers,
frame the problem differently?

Notebook

The question remains open until experience,
property,
relation,
and manifestation
are distinguished more carefully.